1.1 Limits on Freedom

As far as the British were concerned, 1763 was a great year. They had won the French and Indian War—a major victory. Business in the colonies was booming, which put money into the British economy. What could possibly go wrong?

MAIN IDEA After the French and Indian War, the British government enacted laws that restricted some of the colonies' freedoms.

PROBLEMS ARISE

At the end of the French and Indian War, the British colonists in North America had plenty of reasons to be optimistic about their future as British subjects. The colonies' **militias**, or groups of local men who organized to protect their town or colony, had proven themselves to be able fighters alongside British soldiers. After decades of economic growth, the colonies were prosperous. Still, some of the colonists felt a growing dissatisfaction.

The British colonies were the only European settlements in North America where ordinary people could vote for their local legislatures. This freedom to govern, however, was limited by **King George III** and the British Parliament. King George believed the role of a colony was to support the mother country. He was determined to maintain control of Britain's North American colonies.

Concerned about the high cost of the French and Indian War, the king was eager to limit contact between the Native Americans and the colonists in order to keep the peace. As you have read, the king issued a law requiring colonists to stay east of a line drawn on a map along the crest of the Appalachian Mountains. This law was called the **Proclamation of 1763**.

Settlers in the western areas objected to the proclamation. They felt the king was restricting their freedom to expand colonial territories westward. In fact, people continued to settle west of the line decreed by the proclamation. The British government, weighed down by debt from the French and Indian War, could not afford to send soldiers to enforce the law.

SOLDIERS IN THE COLONIES

Soon, colonists along the eastern coast also found themselves frustrated by laws they found oppressive. After the war, many British soldiers were moved into port cities such as New York and Boston to help enforce laws. In 1765, the British Parliament passed the **Quartering Act**. The Quartering Act required colonists to provide



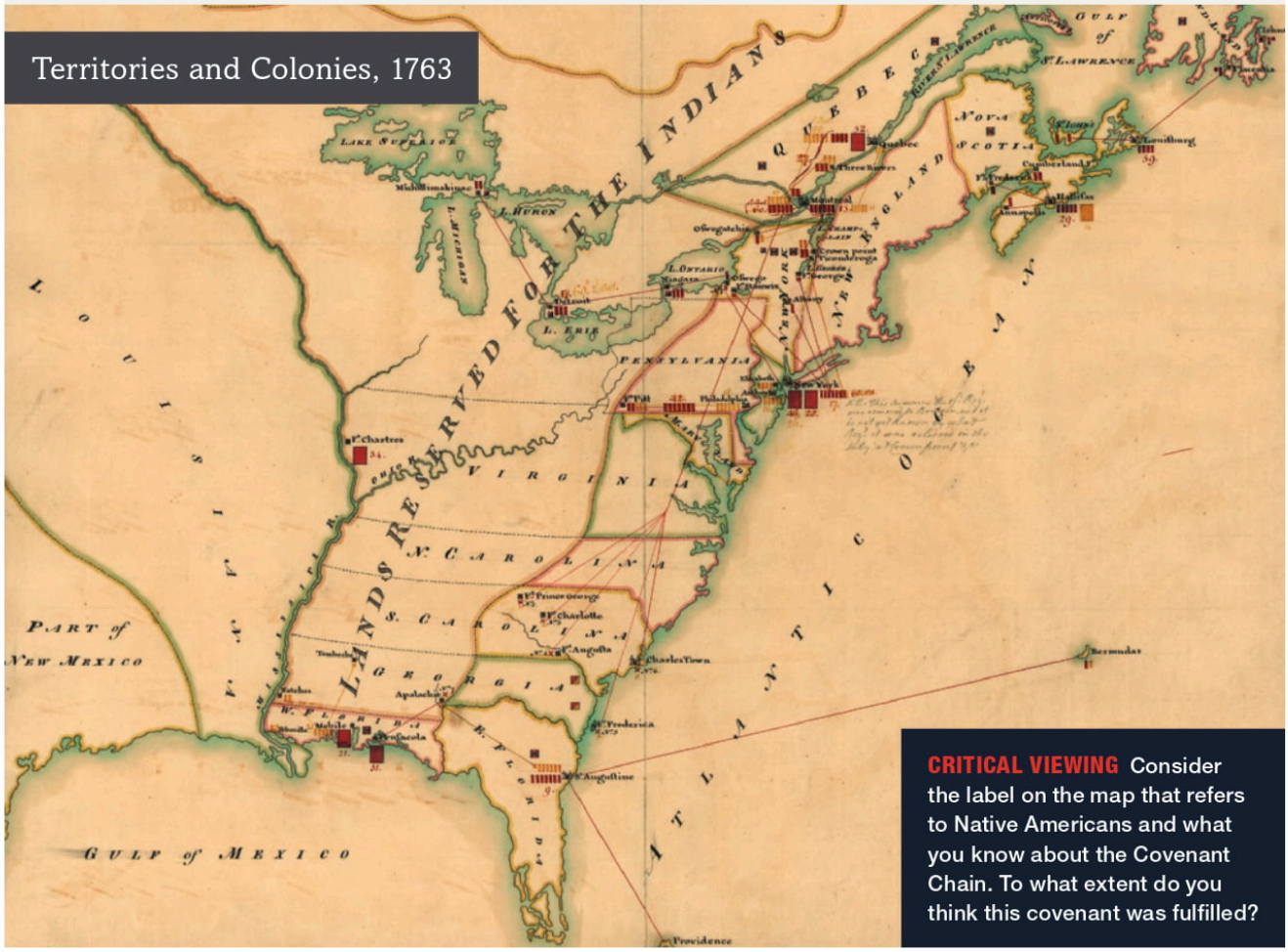
CRITICAL VIEWING This hand-colored engraving (right) shows British soldiers housed in an American home during the 1770s. What do the details in this image help you infer about the colonists' reactions to the Quartering Act?

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The Proclamation of 1763

This historical map shows the land assigned to the colonists and Native Americans by the Proclamation of 1763. The colonists resented the proclamation, and many continued to push west of the Appalachians into land long inhabited by Native Americans. This migration weakened an agreement called the Covenant Chain. A covenant is an agreement or promise between two parties.

The Covenant Chain was a complicated system of alliances established between the nations of the Iroquois League and the northernmost colonies. The chain originated around 1677 and lasted for a century. It helped European settlers and some Native American groups maintain mostly peaceful relationships, but that friendship was tested as new settlers began to claim Native American lands.



Territories and Colonies, 1763

CRITICAL VIEWING Consider the label on the map that refers to Native Americans and what you know about the Covenant Chain. To what extent do you think this covenant was fulfilled?

housing for British soldiers. If a city did not have barracks to house the soldiers, the men were housed in local inns, homes, and stables, or vacant houses or barns.

While the Quartering Act did not allow the British troops to kick people out of their homes, local governments and residents still resented being forced to house the soldiers. The New York colonial assembly refused to enforce the Quartering Act. In all the colonies, the presence of British troops provoked tension and hostility between soldiers and the civilians who had begun to identify less with the British and more as Americans.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the goals of the Proclamation of 1763 and the Quartering Act?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** In what ways were the complaints of eastern and western colonists similar and different?
3. **DETERMINE WORD MEANING** What does *prosperous* mean in the sentence, "After decades of economic growth, the colonists were prosperous"?

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